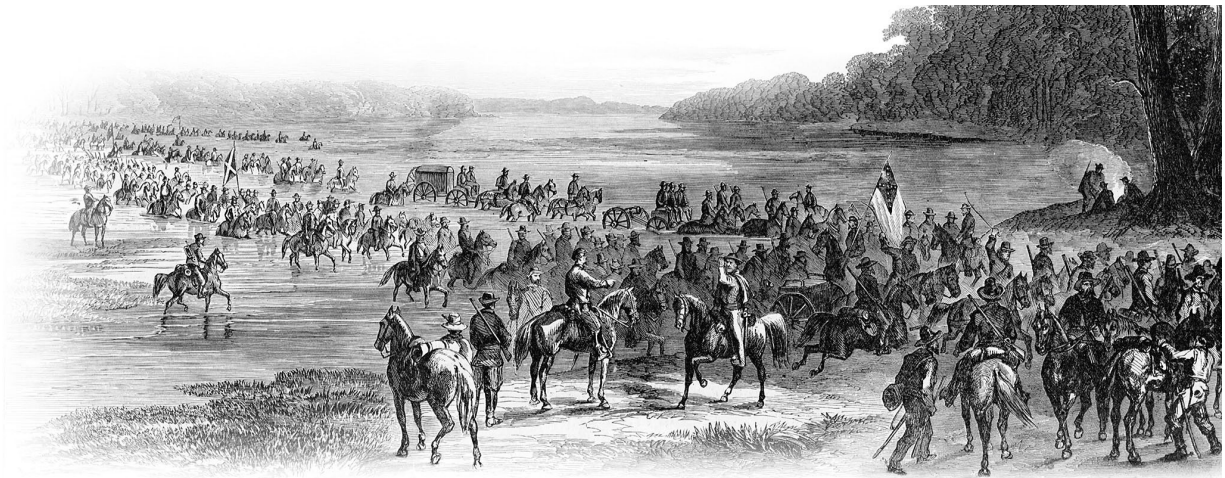


next election. Furthermore, farmers in Virginia would be relieved of the burdens of conflict for at least a season, and the Confederate army could live off the Northerners' land for a change. The chance of recognition by foreign powers might again come back on the table, not to mention an outright peace with the North should Lee and his forces destroy the Army of the Potomac and capture Washington or Baltimore.

The possibility of achieving Southern independence was finally within sight, and when the Confederate cabinet voted on Lee's proposal, only one member, Postmaster General John Reagan, a Texan, disagreed. Longstreet also retained some doubts about the wisdom of the decision, but loyally followed his commander's directives. Lee took off the earlier part of June to rest, resupply his Army of Northern Virginia, and receive reinforcements from the Carolinas and western Virginia. In mid-June, thousands of Confederate soldiers began the long march northward by swinging around to the west and advancing down the Shenandoah Valley.



Lee crosses the Potomac

In mid-June, Lee and his 75,000-strong army crossed the Potomac River into Maryland. This contemporary illustration shows Lee in three-quarter view in the foreground conferring with an officer.

Shock for Stuart

Just as the Army of Northern Virginia was beginning its final preparations for the movement North, the flamboyant Major